

A second mission

In the eight years since its formation, the **Army Paralympic Node** has sought to turn wounded servicemen into elite athletes. This is its story.

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The sun is out on a winter morning in Pune. It seems perfect for lazing around, but for Subedar Dharmaraj Solairaj it is time for off-season training. He has big goals for 2026, and that means he is unlikely to be found on the synthetic track of the Army Sports Institute at Ghorpadi, in the heart of the city.

Even if you are not particularly clued into sport, a glance at Solairaj is enough to tell you what he does for a living. With his broad-shouldered, lithely muscled six-foot-two frame, Solairaj looks every bit an elite athlete.

An elite para athlete, to be precise. Slotted

into a plastic socket on Solairaj's left knee, where his calf muscle should be, is an alien-looking 'J'-shaped black and grey prosthetic. An 'Ossur Cheetah Xpanse' carbon fibre jumping blade, he will tell you later.

The combination of one human foot and one synthetic one, which gives the impression that he is constantly on tiptoe, makes Solairaj's gait jerky and slightly unnatural. On the long jump track, though, flesh and blood, carbon fibre and plastic

